



What is Pharming?

Pharming has been called the 'next generation' of Phishing. Phishing requires a person to respond to a phoney e-mail in order to be taken to an illegitimate site; in Pharming, the targeted person need not respond to anything—he or she is automatically whisked to the illegitimate site.

How does Pharming work?

Pharmers use 'DNS poisoning', or domain hijacks, to redirect users to illegitimate URLs in an attempt to gather personal data. DNS Poisoning is when your DNS files are 'poisoned' with bad information. So, for example, if you have a record that points to a trusted host, a hacker with malicious intent can change it and point you in a different direction.

Domain hijacking is when a hacker takes over a domain name illegally and directs traffic coming to that domain to wherever he wants to take it. Both methods can be used to direct users to fake Web sites that look like legitimate ones, and make users disclose personal information.

When did Pharming first appear on the scene?

Pharming is simply a new application of well-known security weaknesses. There is no 'first Pharming attack ever'.

Who pharms?

Pharmers are the same kind of identity thieves who used techniques such as Phishing. Pharming is more sophisticated because it does not require the intervention of the user!

Where have I seen an instance of Pharming?

The recent hijack of New York ISP Panix is typical of the type of threat that might emerge—such a domain hijack could well be the first step in a Pharming attack.

hope to secure channel partners in India with vertical expertise in financial services, manufacturing, BPO and healthcare, as we believe that these sectors would be the first adopters of PC blades in our country."

The ClearCube solution aims at centralising all PC computing assets into PC blades at a secure location, with end-users connected to the blades through small devices called User Ports. The PC blade computing solution comprises of the User Ports, 'cages', the PC blade, and the ClearCube Management Suite (CMS).

The User Port connects computer peripherals such as the monitor, keyboard, mouse, etc. to PC blades at the data centre or telecom closet. The ClearCube cage is a centralised chassis that houses upto eight PC blades. The PC blade is each user's actual computer. It includes processors, RAM, a hard drive and a video card. The CMS helps IT administrators manage the complete ClearCube infrastructure from any location.

THE SCOTS ARE COMING

Scotland Invites Investments From India

Scottish Development International (SDI), a joint venture between the Scottish Government and Scottish enterprise, is seeking to attract overseas investors to Scotland. They would like companies to invest in R&D centres, joint ventures with regional companies, and technology transfer subsidiaries. Shivendra

Singh, country manager, SDI, says, "We look forward to Indian companies investing in microelectronics, telecom technologies, the animation industry and life sciences." Scotland is one of the most preferred European locations for companies looking for an offshore setup. Singh attributes this to the high quality of manpower, number of graduates, employee loyalty and the cost of setting up shop.

Scotland is also a preferred location for contact centre operations. The reason being cited for this is high-quality multilingual staff at lower cost, low attrition rates, and a favourable time zone.

Scotland recently won the European Region of the Future 2004-05 Award, presented by FDI magazine.

Sounds like the good times for India will keep rolling!

DVD PIRATES AVAST!

New DVD Protection Technology

Content-protection company Macrovision has released a new DVD copy-protection technology in hopes of substantially broadening its role in Hollywood's anti-piracy efforts. The copy-proofing on today's DVDs was broken in 1999; courts have ordered that DVD-copying tools be taken off the market,

but variations of the software remain widely available online.

Macrovision executives said that even if it's not perfect, the new RipGuard DVD technology can prevent much of the copying done with such tools and can help bolster studios' DVD sales.

"Encryption standards either work or they don't," said Adam Gervin, Macrovision's senior director of marketing. "Now the cat's out of the bag. (DVD sales) are going to be one of the main sources of revenue for Hollywood for a long time, so why leave billions of dollars on the table when you can do something about it?"

FASTER INTEL CHIPS

More Cache Per Chip

Intel recently announced a new line of Pentium 4 desktop chips, which contain 2 MB of secondary cache—twice as much as current Pentium 4s.

The new 600 series of Pentium 4s consists of four chips ranging from 3 GHz to 3.6 GHz—all of them with an 800 MHz bus. Prices range from \$605 (Rs 26,300) for the Pentium 4 660 (in quantities of 1,000) and \$224 (Rs 9,700) for the 630.

Also unveiled was the latest Pentium 4 Extreme Edition family—running at 3.73 GHz with a 1.066 GHz bus. These chips are made for high-end gaming PCs and serious technology geeks.

From mid-2005 onwards, Intel will start selling only dual-core processors.

These are not as fast as single-core chips, but with an equivalent of two separate 'brains', will offer better performance. ■

Compiled by Aditya Kuber, Ahmed Shaikh, Meera Vankipuram, Preethi Chamikutty, Ram Mohan Rao and Renuka Rane

